unembarrassing to ask if he had read any of the stories of the Foundation series.

"Oh yes," he said. "They are very good, and the author is your namesake. He's Isaac, also."

"His last name," I said, "is also a namesake of mine. For my last name is Asimov, just as his is."

After that we were inseparable.

We left Birch toft on September 2. The two weeks cost us, all told —special expenses, tips, and everything—$250, and we felt it was well worth it. We were getting a little less cramped about money.

3

The science-fiction book-publishing business was catching. If Doubleday began, could the other publishers be far behind?

On September 6, 1949, I got a letter from Little, Brown, one of the

two large publishing firms based in Boston. (The other was Houghton-Mifflin.) They wanted to know if I had a science-fiction book for them.

I called up all atremble and a young woman, Jane Lawson, invited me to lunch on the eighth to discuss the matter. It was the first time I had occasion to deal with a woman editor. Considering my bringing up in the male world of early magazine science fiction, I wouldn't have thought such a thing could exist.

She took me to Locke-Ober's, Boston's most prestigious restaurant, which I visited for the first time. She insisted that I have a fancy meal, and I didn't have the nerve to cross her—she was an editor, after all.

Since she ordered a whiskey sour, so did I, and since she ordered a shrimp cocktail, so did I. Then she had swordfish (which I had tasted for the first time some weeks before—Boston is famous for its seafood) but insisted I order the more expensive lobster. I did, and struggled with it, for I may have had lobster before (I don't remember) but I was certainly not at the stage where I could handle it easily. And then apple pie a la mode and coffee.

I didn't enjoy a bite of it because I knew that the bill would come to about ten